

Routers above Rs. 11,000

Brand	ZYXEL	D-Link	Apple	Apple
Model No	NBG 460N	DIR-455	Time Capsule 1 TB	AirPort extreme
Price (Rs)	13,000	13,500	27,200	11,450
Grand Totals (Out of 100)	76.00	40.38	79.64	53.47
Features (Out of 20)	11.51	12.14	12.79	12.47
Performance (Out of 80)	64.49	28.24	66.85	41.00
Features				
Protocols Supported (802.11 a / b / g / Draft n / Draft 2)	N / N / N / Y / N	N / Y / Y / N / N	Y / Y / Y / Y / N	N / Y / Y / Y / N
Type Of WAN Port (Ethernet / ADSL / USB)	Ethernet	Ethernet	Ethernet	Ethernet
No Of RJ45 (LAN) Ports	4	4	3	4
No Of USB Ports	0	0	1	1
Device Features:				
Power / Connectivity / LAN / Activity Indicators (Y/N)	Y / Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / N / Y	Y / Y / N / Y
Security Indicator / Hardware Security button (Y / N)	Y / Y	N / N	N / N	N / N
Factory-Defaults Reset Button (Y / N)	Y	Y	Y	Y
Wall Mountable (Y/N)	N	Y	N	N
External storage	N	N	Y	Y
3G / CDMA / data card feature	N	Y/N/N	N	N
Security:				
Encryption Types	WPA / WPA2	WPA / WPA2 / WEP	WPA / WPA2 / WEP	WPA/WPA2/WEP
Firewall (Types Supported)	SPI	SPI / NAT	NAT	NAT
LAN I/P Based Site Blocking (Y/N)	N	N	Y	N
Wireless Isolation (Y/N)	N	N	Y	Y
Port Mapping (Forwarding)	Y	Y	Y	Y
Firmware Interface Features:				
Basic Setup Wizard (CD / Browser) (Y / N)	Y	Y	Y	Y
Online / Offline Firmware Upgrade (Y/N)	N / Y	N / Y	N / Y	N / Y
Settings, Backup To HDD / Load From HDD (Y / N)	Y / Y	Y / Y	Y / Y	Y / Y
Ease of Installation/Use (So 10)				
Bundle (Includes Software, except firmware)	6	6	5	5
Firmware Interface	6	6.5	5	5
Device Configurable Settings	6.5	5	4.5	4.5
Build Quality	6	6	8	8
Performance				
Zone 1 (100 MB File transfer)				
Signal Strength in Zone 1 (Wireless Mon 3.0, %)	80	61	63	60
Sequential (MBps)	6.27	1.85	7.75	8.20
Assorted files (MBps)	3.53	1.52	4.08	3.76
Zone 2 (50 MB File transfer)				
Signal Strength in Zone 2 (Wireless Mon 3.0, %)	65	43	42	45
Sequential (MBps)	8.29	1.40	7.92	2.14
Assorted files (MBps)	4.73	1.40	4	3.09
Zone 3 (50 MB File transfer)				
Signal Strength in Zone 3 (Wireless Mon 3.0, %)	28	11	15	0
Sequential (MBps)	1.69	0	3.02	0
Assorted files (MBps)	1.64	0	2.38	0
Passmark Performance (Mbps)				
Zone 1	6.65	1.88	7.53	6.23
Zone 2	6.45	1.64	7.07	4.92
Zone 3	1.74	0.01	3.13	1.22
Video Streaming (So 10)				
HD 1080p - Zone 1 / 2 / 3	8 / 8 / 8	8 / 8 / 0	8 / 8 / 8	8 / 8 / 0
DVD - Zone 1 / 2 / 3	8 / 8 / 8	8 / 8 / 0	8 / 8 / 8	8 / 8 / 3

server, external storage etc. Performance is something it ought to do well to justify the cost.

Performance

The Apple Time Capsule and the Zyxel NBG-460N did rather well in the performance tests. Both the products did extremely well while transferring files to and from the laptop, in the same room and the adjoining room. Video streaming is no issue either. The D-Link DIR-455 fails to impress from one floor above.

Conclusion

The SMCWBR14S-N4 is our best performer amongst the cheapest of routers. It happens to be one of those really cheap 802.11n routers at just Rs. 2,400. If you aren't paranoid about security and the file sharing features, you can safely go in for it. The D-Link is your next best option - it's a whole Rs. 500 cheaper. It too is an 802.11n router and offers most of the performance as the SMC.

In sheer Wi-Fi performance, the Belkin N300 Surf leads the Buffalo WHR-HP-GN by a tiny

margin. The Belkin however is cheaper. If you're looking at value-for-money, then the D-Link DIR-615 should be your choice.

The SMC SMCWBR11S-3GN with its low pricing is the Best Buy winner in the Rs. 5001 to Rs.

8,000 category. For that price, you get decent performance in the adjoining rooms, a decent feature set that includes the 3G

data card function. If money is no constraint, the Netgear WNR3500 at Rs. 7,900 is the one to go for. It destroys the competition by a decent bit.

This is where products get really expensive. For home users, who want to setup a small network storage device using their router, this is the category to look at - Rs. 8,001 to Rs. 11,000. The WRT320N is the fastest of the lot and it comes bundled with decent features. The Buffalo WZR-HP-G300NH is the more affordable option. It's not as fast as the Linksys WRT320N but it carries the USB port useful for sharing data.

The Apple Time Capsule 1TB has all the features you want including a large disk space. Other than the minor hiccups we faced while setting it up, it performs well in all the file transfer tests. The lone Zyxel router in the test gets the Best Buy for this section. It comes very close to matching the speeds of the Apple Time Capsule.

After running through all the routers, we've come to clear conclusion that 802.11n routers are here to stay. We've seen them increase performance by a lot. To be honest, for just browsing you would be fine with any 802.11g that works in all rooms and a floor above.

802.11g might just cut it for DVD quality video but it isn't cut out for HD video streaming. We're glad 802.11n routers are dropping in prices and

if you spend that little bit more, you should and go in for a decent 802.11n router. **A**



Zyxel NBG-460N